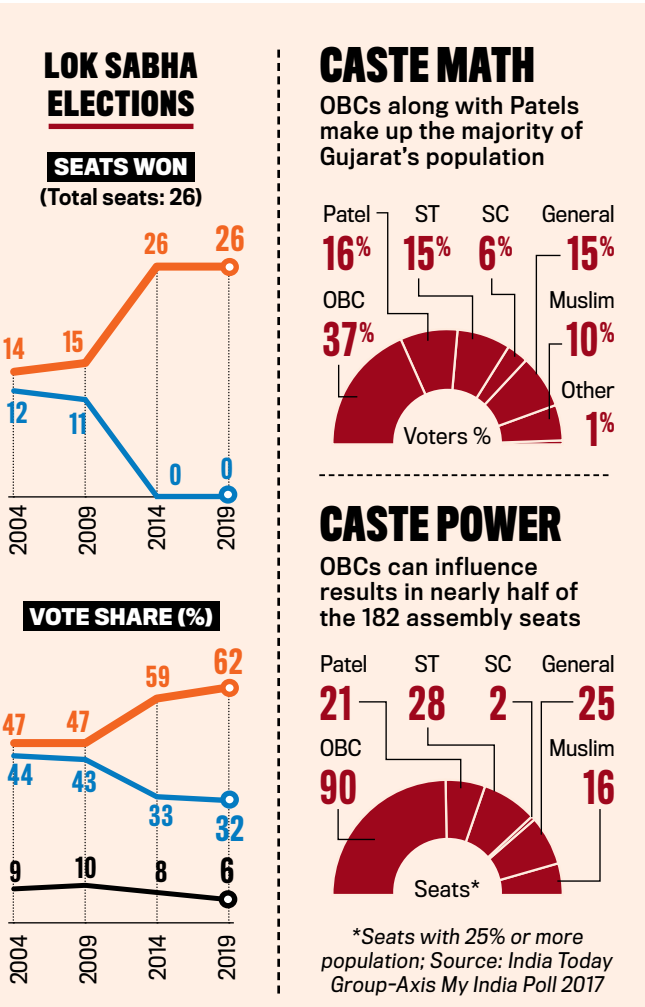
at the helm of the state for a record 12 and a half years. Modi evokes in them that rare quality called Gujarati *asmita* (pride in identity). His party has remained unbeatable in state elections since 1995; since 2002, it has flowed from this conflation of Modi with Gujarat.

Modi didn't ask the audience to repeat the BJP campaign slogan of '*Aa Gujarat, mai banavyu chhe* (I have made this Gujarat)'. But, in his address, he devoted much time to reminding people how he had ensured that the BJP governments both at the Centre and in the state had brought major development schemes to the city. Speaking in the local Gujarati dialect with intonations so nuanced that the audience listened enthralled, he went on to cite specific examples of the work done for them. He then asked them for a personal favour—to go to the homes of voters in the town and ask them to vote. "Treat this as a pilgrimage," he said, "talk of the good work done by the BJP and ask them to come out and vote on polling day. But do me a personal favour, will you? Tell them that our Narendrabhai had come to Navsari and give them my *pranaam* (regards)." The crowd went into raptures and responded in the affirmative. Encouraged, Modi continued, "Tell them it is their votes, their *aashirvad* (blessings) that will allow me to continue the good work I have been doing for the country." Meghna Amdavadi, a BJP worker who had been sitting in the front row, summed up the sentiments of all those who were present. "We regard Narendrabhai not as a father figure but as our elder brother," she said, resplendent in the party colours she is wearing, a saffron sari, cap and scarf. "He is someone with whom we can share our troubles and who constantly helps the whole family in whatever way he can. He will always get our votes."

Gujarat goes to the polls in two phases—on December 1 and 5—and there is little doubt that Narendra Modi will be a decisive factor in determining the outcome of the elec-




Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY



**IN CHARGE**
Modi with Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel at Amod, Bharuch, Oct. 10

**THE BJP IS HOPING TO NOT JUST TOP ITS HIGHEST TALLY OF 127 SEATS IN 2002 BUT ALSO BEST CONGRESS RECORD OF 149 SEATS IN 1985**